bid for expanded partnership with Tehran was trumped by Moscow in the military arena and by Berlin, Paris, and London in the diplomatic sphere. The fact that China withdrew so quickly once confronted by Russian and European bids may also show that Beijing recognises the Middle East region as one of extreme complexity and fluidity in which mis-steps that might embarrass China's leaders are difficult to avoid.

India–China rivalry in Iran and India's strategic autonomy

Given Tehran's strong anti-US orientation, India's strategic partnership with the United States could handicap New Delhi's efforts to woo Tehran. Conversely, New Delhi's partnership with Iran might erode India's partnership with Washington. New Delhi thus needed to stress to both Tehran and Washington the independence of India' cooperative ties with the other. This was done in terms of India's tradition of strategic autonomy, with India insisting that its ties with both Iran and the United States are predicated on *India's own interests* with each and that India hopes for both Iranian *and* American understanding in this regard.

In February 2013, India's Minister of External Affairs Salman Khurshid (Manmohan Singh's last foreign minister) explained why India's strategic partnership with the United States *did not* constitute an obstacle to India's strategic partnership with Iran and could, in fact, work in Tehran's favour.[26] This was still a year away from Narendra Modi's election as Prime Minister, but at the beginning of Obama's second term as president and just as diplomatic interactions that would eventually lead to the 2015 nuclear deal with Iran were beginning to gain steam. Iran and India remained